

Introduction to Refutation & Weighing

Refuting Arguments Pt. 1

“Team X will win the basketball game against Team Y because Team X has taller players than Team Y. What this means is that Team X will qualify for the regional championship.”

Refutation is the process of answering a an opponent’s argument. Always refer to other speakers as “Senators/Representatives”. Be kind, generous, and gracious with remarks. Necessary for full points on speech! Shows engagement in chamber.

There are many ways to attack an argument. In this particular argument,

- You could challenge **the factual basis of the claim**. In the first example, perhaps Team Y was in fact taller than Team X.
- Another way to go would be to **attack the reasoning/warrant**. In the first example you could point out that the taller team does not always win basketball games. You could find examples of games that were not won by the taller team. You could say that other factors such as shooting ability, experience, effort, and coaching might be equally or more important factors in winning.

Refuting Arguments Pt. 2

Now that you've both identified the flaws in your opponent's argument, flowed it down, you have a compelling reason to prove why it's wrong, you need to follow these four SSSSteps.

1. **SIGNPOST** your opponent's argument - i.e., 'Senator ____ on the affirmation contends that dogs are better than cats because dogs are cuter.'
2. **STATE** your counterclaim - i.e., 'This is incorrect...'
3. **SUPPORT** your stance - i.e., 'because empirics have shown that cats, on the scale of objective cuteness and anthropometry, are in fact cuter. turn to the University of Melbourne in August 2013 which explains that this is true because of feline facial structure being more favorable to the majority of humans.'
4. **SUMMARIZE** why it matters - i.e., 'if cuteness is going to determine this argument, your vote is on the negation.'

Refuting Arguments Pt. 3

This is what it looks like when I SIGNPOST, STATE, SUPPORT, AND SUMMARIZE.

Senator _____ on the affirmation contends that dogs are better than cats because dogs are cuter (SIGNPOST). This is incorrect (STATE) ***because** empirics have shown that cats, on the scale of objective cuteness and anthropometry, are in fact cuter. turn to the University of Melbourne in August 2013 which explains that this is true because of feline facial structure being more favorable to the majority of humans (SUPPORT). if cuteness is going to determine this argument, your vote is on the negation (SUMMARIZE).

*The reason you identified your opponent's argument as flawed is the "because" referenced above. This could be a flaw in the factual basis of the argument, or the logic and reasoning of the argument.

Refutation Pre-Reqs. Pt. 1

Research both sides of the issue - You cannot accurately refute what you don't understand!

Example 1 (attacks the factual basis): Alaska's Universal Basic Income (UBI) program

- Many people in favor of UBI say that Alaska has one. However, Alaska's UBI program is not without its problems:
 - **Alaska has oil revenue and had to cut many social programs to accomplish that**

Example 2 (exploits a logical fallacy): Legalize marijuana because it has medical benefits

- The negation could argue that the affirmation's argument is flawed by attacking the logical assumptions made.
 - "How do you know that marijuana has medical benefits?". Further by providing evidence that supports **"Marijuana has harmful side effects such as addiction, impaired memory, and increased risk of psychosis"**.

By undermining the warrant, the negative team shows that the affirmative team's argument is not sound or logical, and that their claim is not supported by valid or reliable evidence.

Researching your opponent's arguments and understanding their logical/factual fallacies is the only way you can respond to them effectively.

Prepping Refs.

Be sure to keep what your
refutation blocks in one
place!

[Mitigate]1st, Alaska is able to do this through their oil revenue, where [Sundlee'19](#) reports that Alaska deposits at least 25 percent of mineral royalties to fund their UBI, the rest of the US does not have that luxury, making funding a national UBI extremely costly.

[Turn]2nd, The Alaska example actually helps our side because according to the [US bureau of labor statistics](#), Alaska has the highest unemployment in the country even though it has a UBI.

[Turn]3rd, The Alaska example actually further helps our side because it proves that once the people have UBI, it is hard to cut it. No politician can dismantle UBI without paying an electoral price. [Sundlee'19](#) reports that once the oil prices fell in 2015, the governor was forced to cut the UBI in half, and during the next election Dunleavy, won the office by promising to increase the UBI, and was then forced to cut all [funding for public broadcasting](#), a [31 percent cut](#) to its critical ferry system, [\\$130 million](#) from Medicaid, and [\\$70 million](#) from the University of Alaska system. This all proves 2 things: 1, politicians in the future can win just with the promise of increased UBI even at the cost of other important programs, and 2, when the economy tanks politicians will be forced to keep up the UBI payments unless they want to be voted out.

Refutation Pre-Reqs. Pt. 2

- Become a Persuasive Speaker:
 - Craft well-structured arguments based on your opponents' responses during the debate round.
 - Analyze their points, identify weaknesses, and develop counterarguments to challenge their claims.
- Strategically Situate Your Argument:
 - An alternative approach to refutation involves strategically aligning your argument with a key voting issue.
 - Identify a crucial aspect of the debate topic that holds significant importance for the audience.
 - Construct your argument in a way that inherently addresses this voting issue.
 - By seamlessly integrating your point with the refutation, you create a powerful and compelling narrative.
 - This approach allows you to capitalize on the audience's preexisting concerns and build a stronger case.
 - Must be able to make that argument without refutation – flexibility is key.

Strategic Argument: Example

Consider a debate about stopping Saudi arms shipments, where a key point is the perceived loss of US leverage. This is a common argument made by the affirmation.

- Precede this by establishing a point that convincingly argues against this notion, seamlessly leading into your refutation.
- Prior to the round, craft an argument in support of stopping arms shipment to the Kingdom “because the United States has lost control over Saudi Arabia’s control of our weapons”
 - If chosen to speak early, you could deliver this argument as it is
 - If chosen to speak later, you could turn your argument into a round defining refutation by simply altering the argument using the four SSSSteps. Here’s how that would unfold:

Senator _____ on the affirmation tells us that we must fail this bill today because when we stop selling arms to Saudi Arabia, we lose leverage we have over the nation. But I want you to understand that that the key fallacy in that argument is assuming that in the status quo that the United States has any leverage left over the way our weapons are used. [Follow up w/ evidence, analysis, and an impact as necessary]